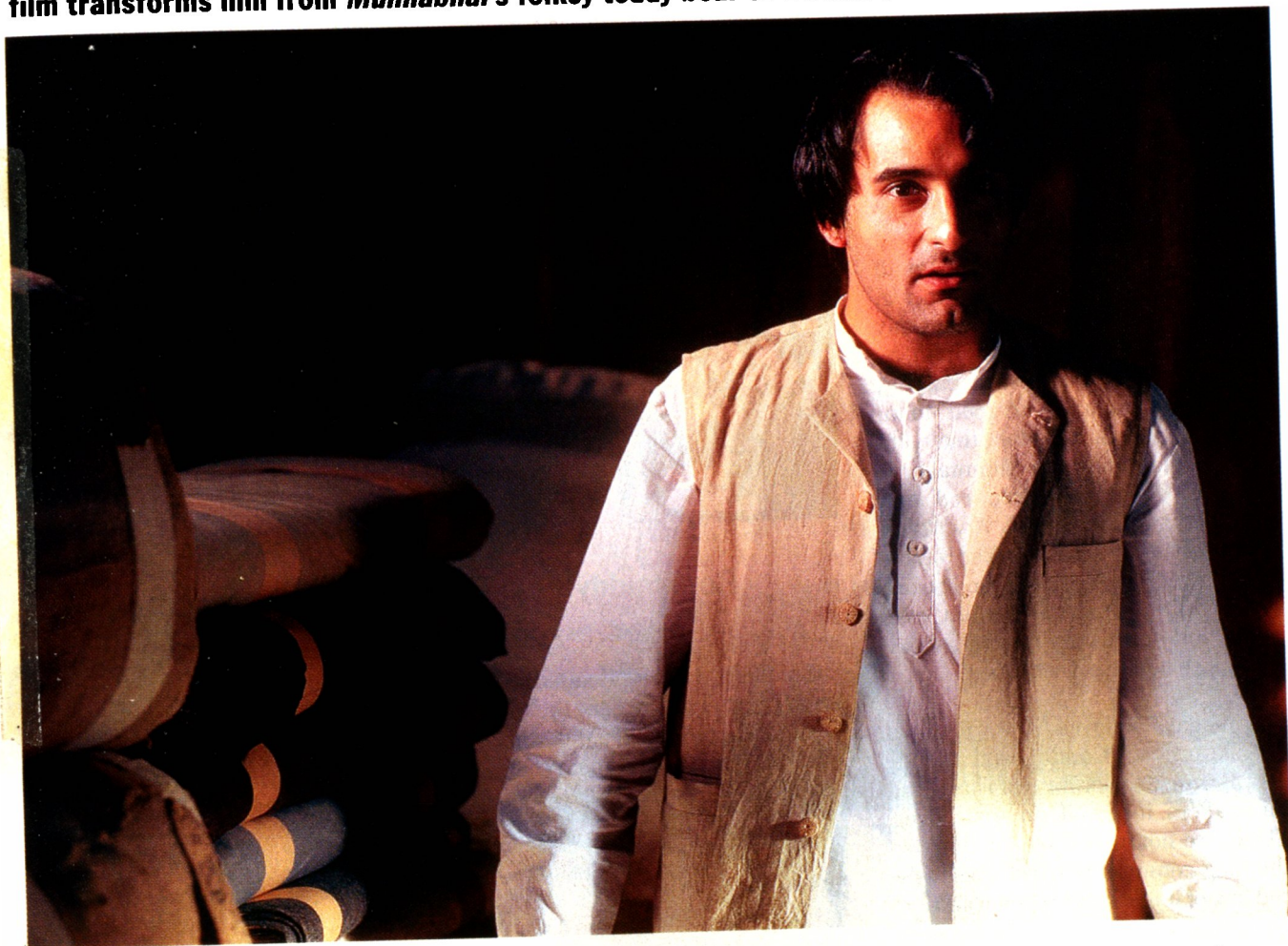


FROM SAINT TO STAR

Bollywood and Indian audiences cannot get enough of the father of the nation, as a new film transforms him from *Munnabhai's* folksy teddy bear to a stern and flawed father



■ By Kaveree Bamzai

It's a heartbreaking scene in *Gandhi, My Father*. The long-haired, disolute-looking Harilal Gandhi is trying to reach the hearse that carries Mahatma Gandhi to his funeral. He loses balance and is trampled upon by a horde of humanity as Jawaharlal Nehru's stirring speech plays in the background: the light has gone out of our lives, he intones.

In more ways than one. While his real heir was dying a beggar, Gandhi's political inheritor Nehru was consolidating his position as the great helmsman. As he led the cortege that moved a nation in its mourning, Nehru was also unconsciously heading towards

his own family's stranglehold over the country's destiny for a significant part of its history—something Gandhi, with his own distaste for promotion of the family, would never have done. From the cuddly folk hero of *Lage Raho Munnabhai* to the troubled father of *Gandhi, My Father*, Gandhi has become all-too-human, both a shorthand for an alternative philosophy in these cul de sac times, as well as the finest politician India ever had.

So whether it is Deepa Mehta's *Water*, where he appears at the end of the film, characteristically at a railway station, sweeping away a child widow in his wake, or in Jahnu Barua's *Maine Gandhi Ko Nahin Mara*, where he is a metaphor for the death of everything

FROM CLICHE TO CULT: Akshaye Khanna as Harilal Gandhi

that is good in contemporary India, or even in *Cheeni Kum*, where he is again an unexpected presence, as the bride-to-be's father attempts a misguided satyagraha, the Mahatma is clearly the most frequently used—even if the lowest paid—character actor in Bollywood.

He's also one who is constantly evolving. He's been the saint in Richard Attenborough's *Gandhi*, a wily politician in Jabbar Patel's *Ambedkar*, and a man struggling with the pressures of family and the nation in Shyam Benegal's *The Making of the Mahatma*. In Feroz Abbas Khan's debut film, *Gandhi, My Father*, he is an ordinary man, a father grappling with